

From Chains to Change

Interpreting Rational Choice Theory through visual art

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The Media Studies and Journalism Department of the University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB) organizes Curriculum Integration (CI) every semester around a particular theme. The purpose of CI is to encourage students to move beyond conventional classroom learning and express theoretical concepts through creative and practical work. For our project, the theme was Rational Choice Theory, which explains that individuals make decisions by considering the possible costs, benefits, consequences and rewards of their choices. According to this theory, people are generally assumed to make choices based on what they believe will provide them with the greatest benefit or the most desirable outcome.

We tried to connect this theoretical concept with the social reality of oppression, freedom and resistance through our visual art project titled “From Chains to Change.” Our project explores how people make choices when they are placed in difficult or oppressive circumstances. A person may choose to remain silent because speaking out can bring risks, or they may choose to resist because freedom, dignity and justice are considered more valuable than the consequences they may face. Through the mask, we wanted to demonstrate that even under pressure, individuals have the ability to make conscious choices that can lead to change.

Our Message

Our main message was “Choice can break the chain.” We wanted to show that people are often surrounded by different forms of social, psychological and physical restrictions. These restrictions can influence their decisions, but they do not completely remove their ability to choose.

The concept of rational choice helped us understand this situation. When a person is facing oppression, fear or inequality, they may calculate the possible consequences before taking action. Remaining silent may appear to be the safer option, while speaking against injustice may involve greater personal risk. However, if freedom and dignity are valued more than temporary safety, a person may rationally choose resistance.

Through our project, we wanted to emphasize that meaningful social change begins with a choice. People may be conditioned by their surroundings or trapped by different forms of social pressure, but choosing to question, resist and act can become the first step toward freedom. Therefore, the chains in our artwork do not only represent physical restriction; they also represent fear, silence, injustice and social limitations.

The title “From Chains to Change” represents this transformation. The chains symbolize the circumstances that hold people back, while the bright dawn on the right side represents hope and the possibility of a better

future. Our message was that change does not happen automatically; it begins when individuals decide to make a different choice.

Layout

We designed the mask as the central element of the entire board because it represents the individual and the different struggles experienced by people. The mask is divided into contrasting visual sections. The darker side represents oppression, darkness and the difficult circumstances that restrict human choices. The brighter side represents hope, freedom and the possibility of change.

One of the most important elements of our design was the chain surrounding the mask. The chain represents the restrictions that prevent people from exercising their choices freely. We also used barbed wire to strengthen the idea of imprisonment, pain and limitation. Behind the mask, we placed figures that appear to be trapped, further emphasizing the idea of people living under restrictions.

The raised fist in the center represents resistance, courage and the decision to fight against oppression. It is an important symbol of agency because it demonstrates that individuals can choose to stand against the circumstances surrounding them.

The right side of the board contains bright red and yellow rays that resemble a sunrise. The sunrise symbolizes hope and a new beginning. The phrase “After the darkest night comes the brightest dawn” was used to communicate that difficult circumstances do not necessarily determine the future. The use of contrasting dark and bright areas visually represents the journey from chains to change.

We also used different colors to communicate different meanings. Black represents darkness, oppression and restriction, while red represents struggle, urgency and resistance. Pink and purple add emotional depth to the central figure, while yellow represents hope, light and a better future.

Painting and Installation

The mask was painted using different shades to create a strong contrast between darkness and hope. We focused on making the mask visually dramatic so that the audience could understand the concept without needing a lengthy explanation. The darker portions were painted to represent oppression, while the brighter colors were used to represent hope and transformation.

The chains and barbed wire were important installation elements because they helped turn the theoretical concept of rational choice into something visually understandable. Rather than simply explaining that people face restrictions, we wanted the audience to actually see those restrictions surrounding the central figure.

One of the challenging aspects of the project was balancing several symbolic elements within a single composition. We had to make sure that the chain, barbed wire, fist, figures and sunrise did not overpower the central mask. Creating the contrast between the dark and bright sides also required careful consideration of color and placement.

The most satisfying part of the process was seeing the individual elements come together to create a complete visual narrative. Initially, the theory of rational choice seemed quite abstract, but while working on the mask, we were able to translate the theory into recognizable symbols of decision-making, restriction, resistance and hope.

Exhibition

The exhibition gave us an opportunity to present our interpretation of Rational Choice Theory through visual art rather than through a conventional academic presentation. Displaying the mask allowed us to observe how people reacted to our use of symbols, colors and composition.

Our artwork was particularly eye-catching because of the contrast between the dark left side and the bright red and yellow right side. The chains, barbed wire and raised fist immediately attracted attention, while the sunrise created a visual transition from darkness to hope.

The exhibition was also an important learning experience because it allowed us to understand that an artwork communicates differently when it is viewed by an audience. As creators, we already knew the theoretical background behind every element, but the exhibition helped us understand whether the audience could identify those meanings from the visual composition itself.

Although displaying the artwork in a larger professional gallery could have allowed us to reach a wider audience, presenting it within the university environment provided us with a comfortable space to share our ideas and receive direct responses. Overall, the exhibition was an important opportunity to apply classroom learning in a creative environment.

Feedback

The feedback from the audience helped us evaluate whether our visual representation successfully communicated the concept of Rational Choice Theory. The responses showed that the central ideas of chains, oppression, resistance and hope were understandable through the artwork.

The contrast between the two sides of the mask was particularly effective in communicating the movement from darkness toward a brighter future. The chains and barbed wire were also easily recognizable as symbols of restriction. At the same time, the raised fist was understood as a symbol of resistance and the decision to challenge oppressive circumstances.

The feedback also helped us realize that visual communication does not always need to directly explain a theory. When symbols are carefully selected and arranged, they can allow an audience to interpret a complex theoretical concept through their own understanding.

However, we also realized that some elements could have been made more precise and visually balanced. If we had another opportunity to work on the project, we would improve certain details of the mask and installation so that every element had an equally clear connection with Rational Choice Theory.

Realization

At the end of the project, we realized that Rational Choice Theory can be applied to many situations beyond the examples discussed in textbooks. Human beings constantly make decisions by considering risks, benefits, consequences and personal values. Sometimes the most rational decision is not necessarily the easiest one. A person may choose a difficult path because the long-term benefit is more valuable than immediate safety or comfort.

Through “From Chains to Change,” we learned that social change can also be understood as a series of choices. A person may remain silent because it seems safer, but another person may decide that resisting injustice is more valuable. That decision can influence others and eventually contribute to larger social change.

The project also taught us that transforming a theoretical concept into visual art requires creativity, teamwork and careful planning. We initially found it challenging to turn an abstract theory like Rational Choice Theory into a physical artwork. However, by using symbols such as chains, barbed wire, the raised fist and the sunrise, we were able to create a visual story.

If we were given the opportunity to do the project again, we would plan the production process more systematically and spend more time refining the smaller visual details. We would also make sure that every element has a clearly defined connection with the central theory.

Role of Individual Members

Both members of our group contributed to the development and completion of the project. We discussed the concept together, exchanged ideas about the visual composition and worked on transforming the theoretical concept into a creative representation. We also worked together during the preparation, painting, decoration and installation process.

Faria Akter (223012075): Contributed to brainstorming and developing the concept, helped with the visual planning and design of the mask, participated in painting and decoration, helped arrange the installation and worked on the documentation and report.

Md. Tariquzzaman Sikder (223012037): Contributed to brainstorming and conceptual development, helped with designing and painting the mask, worked on the installation and decoration, assisted with arranging the visual elements and contributed to the overall presentation of the project.

We divided the responsibilities according to our individual strengths and continuously discussed the progress of the project. Our cooperation and shared effort helped us complete the artwork successfully.

Conclusion

The CI project was a valuable opportunity to understand Rational Choice Theory through practical and creative application. Instead of limiting ourselves to the theoretical definition of rational decision-making, we

explored how people make choices when faced with oppression, fear, restrictions and the possibility of change.

Our mask represents a journey from darkness and restriction toward hope and freedom. The chains and barbed wire symbolize the barriers that restrict individuals, while the raised fist represents the decision to resist. Finally, the bright sunrise represents the possibility of change that can emerge from a difficult situation.

The project also taught us the importance of teamwork, creativity, planning and visual communication. We learned that a complicated academic theory can be communicated effectively when it is connected with familiar symbols and real-life experiences.

Overall, “From Chains to Change” was not only an artistic project but also a learning experience that allowed us to reflect on human decision-making and the power of individual choice. It helped us understand that although circumstances can influence our decisions, the choices we make can also become the starting point for transformation and change.